

Episode 125: Once Upon a Time... 72 – 1994 Part 6 – Meeting! What Were the Results?

The asteroid probe "Hayabusa" is coming home! Ever since hearing that news, I'd been sending encouragement to Hayabusa flying alone through the solar system toward Earth.

And last Sunday late night, it finally returned to Earth. I watched that on Ustream broadcast. Hayabusa, returning after completing its long, long journey of about 6 milliards kilometres. Having overcome countless hardships and returned battered all over, I don't think I was alone in seeing *Space Battleship Yamato* in that figure. Ah, well, I'm that generation (laugh).

I saw several movies that amateurs (?) had created visualising Hayabusa's difficult journey, and several used *Yamato* as BGM. They all matched magnificently! Wonderful! *Space Battleship Yamato* music seems to connect stories with our feelings like this.

Hayabusa returned to Earth but sadly burned up in the atmosphere. At the very end, it photographed Earth and scattered away. Ah, what a story that shook Japanese hearts.

I think about this stuff. While our job is creating various "stories" for people to watch, we really can't beat real stories like Hayabusa's.

Hayabusa's fireball burning up during atmospheric reentry was more magnificent and beautiful than any CG imagery.

Now, changing topics, *The Tatami Galaxy* currently broadcasting to great acclaim. In the Kanto area, this week is Episode 9 "Secret Organisation 'Lucky Cat Chinese Restaurant'" broadcast. Including this week, only three episodes remain. Everyone, please support us! Please look forward to it!

Now then.

March 1994. EEI-TOEI Studio in Manila, Philippines.

With general inspection complete, now for our approach. Regarding several observed problems, to solve them, we decided to gather all staff for meetings. This was the biggest mission assigned to me for this business trip.

The biggest problem with painted results from EEI-TOEI Studio was "dirt." Much dirt was observed on transparent cel parts. Most common among that dirt was paint spattering. Plus fingerprint or palm print attachment.

Technical precision of painting itself—mistakes, overruns and such—has some variation anywhere, domestically or abroad. Particularly for TV works, some degree of problems can be overlooked, but transparent parts coming up dirty was quite problematic.

These fingerprints and palm prints really stood out on dark backgrounds. The production lineup then centered on *Dragon Ball Z* and *Sailor Moon*. Battle scenes and image scenes increased dark background scenes, and fingerprints and palm prints would appear white on screen during battles.

For theatrical or video works, we reinspect cels before photography, so we cleanly wipe fingerprints at that point, but for TV series, Manila painted results basically went straight to photography, so after shooting when rushes came up and we watched previews it was like "Oh no!"...

Naturally this problem was conveyed to Manila studio repeatedly with requests for attention, and while attention would improve things momentarily, after a bit they'd return to the original state. So investigating why this happened and implementing improvement measures was my mission.

Observing their actual work, I understood—they do wear painting gloves during work, but watching them, they'd carelessly press cels with their arms without thinking. Naturally short sleeves meant direct skin contact. Or the hand holding brushes wore gloves, but the opposite hand holding paint bottles was bare skin. When warned they'd properly wear gloves then, but look away briefly and they're working bare-handed again (wry laugh).

So it was ultimately a consciousness problem. Why must you wear gloves? They'd comply when told, but didn't properly understand reasons. Some staff didn't necessarily equate "job of painting cels" with "job of creating anime screens." For example, if this were domestic Japan, they could watch their work's final form on TV broadcasts, which might naturally raise consciousness, but unfortunately what they're currently making can't be watched in Manila. Ah, this is difficult.

Still, somehow including such aspects had to be understood. So, meetings.

The biggest problem here was "language barriers." While I'd talk endlessly in Japanese, English was absolutely hopeless. Reading and writing sentences were generally okay, and I mostly understood what others said, but speaking from my end was weak. I'd try composing English in my head and get mini-panicked. Ah, pitiful child of exam English (wry laugh). I never took English conversation classes or such.

But no problem! Soya-san and Tachisen-san stationed at this studio were already solid with English, so I asked them to interpret meetings. Having my speech somehow skillfully translated. Three meetings were set up between studio delivery schedules. First, one with inspection staff. Based on content exchanged there, one with trace team + painting team, then one with painting team night shift.

I first met with inspection staff because they actually manage cel quality, and I thought they probably had various thoughts too. Points I noticed while touring and trying some work together were probably understood by everyone, and they might have problem points they were more concerned about than me, who could only stay briefly.

Exchanging opinions from that perspective and organising points might make various things penetrate even better to everyone.

So, opinion exchange.

Everyone seemed to understand what I wanted to say, and various opinions emerged during discussion—it was interesting. Conversely, I got various opinions about Tokyo studio colour direction methods and inquiry responses, which revealed many things we needed to improve too.

Next, meetings with trace and painting staff. Honestly, initially they probably just thought "What's this guy?" or "Annoying guy from Tokyo" (laugh), but talking gradually got through to them with individual differences. Various opinions and requests emerged here too—interesting.

Three meetings like that, talking extensively for about 4+ hours total. Quite an intense experience.

Then I departed for home. Return luggage was two aluminium cases so packed full the lids wouldn't properly close. Over 60 kilogrammes. At the airport counter I persistently negotiated overcharge fees in Japanese-mixed English conversation (wry laugh), still paid considerable amounts, and somehow boarded the Tokyo-bound JAL flight.

After that, how much did the business trip results achieve? Not dramatically, but still some improvement occurred. But three months later, during my next theatrical work's crunch, similar situations would repeat (laugh).

(10.06.15)